

Question 18 · Unit 1 · 8 Marks

State any two reasons why an HRD professional needs to understand organisational culture.

Answer

Culture is the context in which HRD mechanisms succeed or fail; hence the professional must understand it.

- 1. Reason 1 – Fit of interventions:** Training, appraisal and OD must fit existing values. A highly hierarchical culture will reject blunt 360-degree feedback unless adapted.
- 2. Explanation:** Culture-blind HRD creates resistance and wasted investment.
- 3. Reason 2 – Climate vs culture gap:** The professional must know deep culture to interpret climate survey results and to change climate realistically.
- 4. Change management:** Culture knowledge helps sequence change—what to preserve, what to challenge.
- 5. Communication:** Messages about development must use the organisation's language, stories and heroes.
- 6. Power and politics:** Culture reveals who must sponsor HRD for it to be legitimate.
- 7. Ethics and inclusion:** Understanding subcultures (functions, regions, generations) prevents one-size-fits-all programmes.
- 8. Strategy alignment:** Desired culture (e.g., innovation) tells HRD which competencies and behaviours to develop.

Conclusion. Thus understanding culture is essential for designing acceptable, effective and ethical HRD, not optional background knowledge.